

CLAT Express - January 2026: Study Notes

Chapters, topics and sub-topics with key facts, memory aids and mind-map outlines.

International Relations and News

US Strike on Venezuela

US Military Strike and Justifications

United States forces carried out a military strike on Venezuela, known as Operation Absolute Resolve, which led to the capture of President Nicolas Maduro. Washington cited illegal migration, narcotics trafficking and alleged narco-terrorism, claims that Venezuela strongly contests. The action raised the question of whether a law enforcement objective can justify the use of military force on a sovereign territory.

- Operation Absolute Resolve: US military strike on Venezuela
- Strike locations named: Caracas, Miranda, Aragua and La Guaira
- The strike led to the capture of President Nicolas Maduro
- US justifications: illegal migration, narcotics trafficking, alleged narco-terrorism
- Venezuela rejects these claims and calls them a pretext for regime change
- Washington designated Tren de Aragua and Cartel de los Soles as Foreign Terrorist Organisations
- US alleges Cartel de los Soles operates under the leadership of Maduro
- US alleges Cartel of the Suns collaborated with FARC to traffic cocaine into the US
- Arguments in favour: fentanyl and narco-gangs cause mass American deaths
- Arguments against: crime can become an excuse to violate borders

Mind-map outline

Military Strike and Justifications

- Operation Absolute Resolve
 - Caracas, Miranda, Aragua, La Guaira
 - Maduro captured
- Stated justifications
 - Illegal migration
 - Narcotics trafficking
 - Narco-terrorism
- Designations and allegations
 - Tren de Aragua
 - Cartel de los Soles
 - Alleged FARC collaboration

Venezuela's Political and Economic Crisis

Venezuela has faced a deep political and economic collapse for several years, marked by hyperinflation, power outages, food shortages and a breakdown of healthcare services. The crisis escalated when Juan Guaido, Head of the National Assembly, declared himself Acting President, challenging Maduro's second term that began in January 2019. Nearly 8 million Venezuelans have fled the country since 2013, mainly to Latin American countries.

- Hyperinflation, prolonged power outages and food shortages cause severe humanitarian distress
- Breakdown of healthcare services is part of the humanitarian crisis
- Guaido declared himself Acting President, citing Articles 233 and 333 of the Venezuelan Constitution
- Maduro was sworn in for a controversial second term in January 2019
- The 2018 presidential elections were widely criticised as unfair and non-transparent
- Opposition leaders were barred, imprisoned or exiled
- The opposition-controlled National Assembly called Maduro a 'Usurper'
- Economic contraction under Maduro is largely blamed on corruption, poor governance and overdependence on oil
- Nearly 8 million Venezuelans have fled since 2013, mainly to Latin American countries
- Currency: Venezuelan Bolivar; official language: Spanish

Mnemonic - Causes of Humanitarian Distress: HOPS: Hyperinflation, Outages, Provisions short, Services broken

H = Hyperinflation; O = Prolonged power outages; P = Food shortages; S = Breakdown of healthcare services

Mind-map outline

Political and Economic Crisis

- Economic collapse
 - Hyperinflation
 - Power outages and food shortages
 - Overdependence on oil
- Political dispute
 - Guaido declared Acting President
 - Articles 233 and 333 cited
 - 2018 elections criticised
- Humanitarian impact
 - Healthcare services breakdown
 - Nearly 8 million fled since 2013

US Sanctions and Strategic Interests

Washington imposed comprehensive sanctions on PDVSA, Venezuela's state-owned oil firm, to cut Maduro's access to oil revenue. Because sanctions failed to dislodge the government, the US turned to maritime interdictions aimed at choking oil revenues. Strategic interests include Venezuela's very large oil reserves and its partnerships with China, Russia, Iran and Cuba.

- US imposed comprehensive sanctions targeting PDVSA, the state-owned oil firm
- Sanctions drastically limited Venezuela's oil exports to the US, forcing Caracas to seek alternative buyers
- Maduro severed diplomatic ties with the US and expelled American diplomats
- Venezuela has the world's largest proven crude oil reserves, estimated at over 300 billion barrels
- Sanctions failed to dislodge the Maduro government, so the US turned to maritime interdictions
- Venezuela's partnerships with China, Russia, Iran and Cuba cover energy, defence and finance
- US views these alignments as a challenge to its strategic dominance in the Western Hemisphere
- US revived Monroe Doctrine rhetoric, termed the 'Don-roe Doctrine'
- Caribbean is treated as a critical zone of influence, reminiscent of Cold War-era calculations

Mind-map outline

Sanctions and Strategic Interests

- US sanctions
 - PDVSA targeted
 - Oil exports to US limited
 - Maritime interdictions
- Strategic interests
 - Largest proven oil reserves
 - Western Hemisphere dominance
- Venezuela's partners
 - China and Russia
 - Iran and Cuba

Monroe Doctrine and Limits of Multilateralism

The Monroe Doctrine, proclaimed in 1823, was initially defensive but later became a basis for US intervention in Latin America, expanded through the Roosevelt Corollary of 1904. The UN struggles to prevent unilateral interventions because of Security Council vetoes, unpaid dues and gray-zone tactics. Reform proposals include limiting P5 veto use and creating an accountability protocol for gray-zone threats.

- Monroe Doctrine: unilateral US foreign policy declaration proclaimed in 1823 by President James Monroe
- Originally aimed to stop European powers from re-colonising Latin America
- Roosevelt Corollary (1904) justified US intervention to maintain stability in the Western Hemisphere
- Three core principles: non-colonisation, non-intervention, and US non-interference in Europe

- P5 members (US, Russia, China, UK, France) can block any UN Security Council resolution
- 47 vetoes blocked 37 draft resolutions between 2015 and 2024
- UN faces \$2.4B in unpaid regular dues and a \$2.7B peacekeeping shortfall
- NATO, AU and ECOWAS intervene without UNSC approval
- Modern gray-zone conflicts use cyberattacks, PMCs and proxies
- Reform ideas: limit P5 veto use and introduce a veto override for mass atrocities

Mnemonic - Three Ns of the Monroe Doctrine: Three Ns: No new colonies, No meddling in independent states, Neutral about Europe's wars

N1 = Non-colonisation: no new European colonies in the Americas; N2 = Non-intervention: no European interference in independent American states; N3 = US non-interference: the US stays out of European wars and colonial affairs

Mind-map outline

Monroe Doctrine and UN Limits

- Monroe Doctrine
 - Proclaimed 1823
 - Roosevelt Corollary 1904
 - Three core principles
- UN limits
 - P5 vetoes block resolutions
 - \$2.4B unpaid regular dues
 - Regional blocs act without UNSC
- Reform ideas
 - Limit P5 veto use
 - Gray-zone accountability protocol

Strategic Importance of Greenland

Greenland's Status within Denmark, NATO and the EU

Greenland is one of Denmark's two autonomous territories and became a Danish colony after Hans Egede's expedition arrived in 1721. It became a self-governing territory in 1979 and has held the right to declare independence through a referendum since 2009. Through Denmark it is part of NATO, while it is associated with the EU as one of the EU Overseas Countries and Territories.

- Greenland is the world's largest island and one of Denmark's two autonomous territories
- The other autonomous territory of Denmark is the Faroe Islands
- Greenland became a Danish colony in the early 18th century after Hans Egede's expedition arrived in 1721
- Greenland became a self-governing territory in 1979
- Since 2009 Greenland has had the right to declare independence through a referendum
- Greenland is part of NATO by default because Denmark is a NATO member
- Greenland is not an EU member state but is associated with the EU as an Overseas Country and Territory
- Greenlanders are considered to be EU citizens
- Greenland joined the European Community with Denmark in 1973 and left it in 1985

Mnemonic - Greenland's milestones: Egede, Seventy-Nine, Oh-Nine

Egede = Hans Egede's expedition arrived in 1721 and Greenland became a Danish colony; Seventy-Nine = Greenland became a self-governing territory in 1979; Oh-Nine = Since 2009 Greenland has had the right to declare independence through a referendum

Mind-map outline

Greenland's status

- Autonomy
 - Denmark's two autonomous territories
 - Self-governing since 1979
 - Referendum right since 2009
- Alliances
 - NATO through Denmark
 - EU Overseas Countries and Territories
 - Greenlanders are EU citizens

- History
 - Danish colony from 18th century
 - Hans Egede expedition, 1721

US Strategic and Military Ties with Greenland

The United States seized temporary control of Greenland during the Second World War to stop Nazi Germany from exploiting the Danish colony. It proposed a \$100 million purchase offer to Denmark in 1946 and formalised American military access through a 1951 defence agreement. Today the US maintains Pituffik Space Base, which helps monitor potential missile threats.

- The US seized temporary control of Greenland in World War II
- The aim was to prevent Nazi Germany from exploiting the Danish colony after Denmark's occupation
- In 1946 the US proposed a \$100 million offer to Denmark for outright purchase of Greenland
- The 1951 US-Denmark Defence Agreement formalised American military access to Greenland
- Pituffik Space Base, formerly known as Thule Air Base, is maintained by the US
- The base monitors potential missile threats from Russia, China and North Korea
- Greenland hosts critical infrastructure for the US Ballistic Missile Early-Warning System
- Greenland lies within the GIUK Gap, a key chokepoint for monitoring naval movements in the North Atlantic
- Greenland's ground stations can track polar-orbiting satellites
- Greenland enhances NATO's ability to monitor Russian activities in the Arctic and North Atlantic

Mnemonic - US milestones in Greenland: Forty-Six Offer, Fifty-One Access

Forty-Six = In 1946 the US proposed a \$100 million offer to Denmark for outright purchase of Greenland; Fifty-One = The 1951 US-Denmark Defence Agreement formalised American military access to Greenland

Mind-map outline

US interest in Greenland

- Historical ties
 - WWII temporary control
 - 1946 offer of \$100 million
 - 1951 defence agreement
- Pituffik Space Base
 - Formerly Thule Air Base
 - Monitors missile threats
- Security role
 - GIUK Gap naval monitoring
 - Ballistic missile early warning
 - Polar satellite ground stations

Critical Minerals and Emerging Arctic Shipping Routes

Greenland has large untapped reserves of rare earth elements, which are crucial for semiconductors, renewable energy and defence systems. These reserves offer the West an alternative supply chain to China-dominated rare earth markets. Melting Arctic ice is opening new maritime corridors, such as the Transpolar Sea Route, that could shorten Atlantic-Pacific travel and bypass the Panama and Suez Canals.

- Greenland possesses large untapped reserves of rare earth elements
- Rare earth elements are crucial for semiconductors, renewable energy technologies and defence systems
- China dominates the rare earth elements market
- Greenland offers the West an alternative supply chain to China-dominated rare earth markets
- Melting Arctic ice is opening new maritime corridors
- The Transpolar Sea Route is one of the emerging Arctic shipping routes
- New Arctic routes could reduce travel time between the Atlantic and Pacific Oceans
- New Arctic routes could lower fuel and shipping costs
- New Arctic routes could bypass the Panama Canal and Suez Canal
- Control over Arctic sea lanes will shape future global trade and naval power projection

Mind-map outline

Minerals and Arctic routes

- Rare earth elements
 - Large untapped reserves
 - Used in semiconductors and defence
 - Alternative to China-dominated market
- Arctic shipping routes
 - Melting ice opens corridors
 - Transpolar Sea Route
 - Bypass Panama and Suez Canals

Great Power Competition and the EU Anti-Coercion Instrument

China labels itself a Near-Arctic State and invests in Arctic research, while Russia has heavily militarised its Arctic coastline and the US views Greenland as central to countering both.

Denmark's firm stance highlights the tension between territorial sovereignty and the strategic ambitions of major powers. The EU's Anti-Coercion Instrument, nicknamed the Trade Bazooka, is primarily a deterrent tool against economic coercion.

- China labels itself a 'Near-Arctic State'
- China is investing in Arctic research and infrastructure
- Russia has heavily militarised its Arctic coastline
- The US views Greenland as central to countering both China and Russia
- Denmark takes a firm stance on sovereignty over Greenland
- The EU's Anti-Coercion Instrument is nicknamed the 'Trade Bazooka'
- The Anti-Coercion Instrument is primarily a deterrent tool with capacity for proportionate retaliation
- The Anti-Coercion Instrument responds when a non-EU country seeks to coerce the EU through trade or investment measures
- Its objectives are to deter economic coercion and protect the EU's strategic autonomy
- A French President urged the EU to invoke the Anti-Coercion Instrument for the first time against US tariffs amid the Greenland dispute

Mnemonic - Anti-Coercion countermeasures: Traders In Markets Interact

T = Trade measures: import and export restrictions on goods and services; I = Investment measures: restrictions on foreign direct investment; M = Market access: limiting access to the EU internal market; I = IP and services: measures affecting intellectual property rights, public procurement and services

Mind-map outline

Competition and EU response

- Major powers
 - China: Near-Arctic State
 - Russia: militarised Arctic coastline
 - US: Greenland central to countering both
- Denmark
 - Firm stance on sovereignty
- Anti-Coercion Instrument
 - Nicknamed Trade Bazooka
 - Primarily a deterrent
 - Proportionate retaliation if coercion persists

Board of Peace for Gaza

Charter, Mandate and Leadership

The US is constituting a Board of Peace, a US-led inter-governmental body established under UN Security Council Resolution 2803 (2025) and linked to the 20-point Gaza peace plan. Its charter has 13 Articles, and its chair is the US President. The Board's mandate covers supervising Gaza's civil and security bodies, mobilising assistance and ensuring accountability during Gaza's transition.

- Type: US-led inter-governmental body
- Established under UN Security Council Resolution 2803 (2025)
- Charter contains 13 Articles on membership, financial contributions and dispute redressal
- Mandate: supervise and guide NCAG (civil administration) and ISF (security)

- Mandate: mobilise international financial and technical assistance
- Mandate: ensure transparency, coordination and accountability during transition
- Chair: US President Donald Trump, who also serves separately as Inaugural Representative of the US
- Chair can be removed only if he resigns voluntarily or is unanimously declared incapable by the Executive Board
- Executive Board includes former UK PM Tony Blair, US Secretary of State Marco Rubio, World Bank President Ajay Banga and Jared Kushner
- US announced the Board meets with 19 countries; India is absent from this high-level initiative

Mnemonic - Mandate of the Board: Super Mentors Enable

S = Supervise and guide NCAG and ISF; M = Mobilise international financial and technical assistance; E = Ensure transparency, coordination and accountability

Mind-map outline

Board structure and charter

- Charter
 - 13 Articles
 - Membership rules
 - Financial contributions and dispute redressal
- Chair
 - US President Donald Trump
 - Also Inaugural Representative of US
 - Removal: resignation or unanimous incapacity finding
- Executive Board
 - Select global leaders
 - Blair, Rubio, Banga, Kushner
- Authority
 - Established under UNSC Resolution 2803 (2025)
 - US-led inter-governmental body

Membership and Gaza Governance Bodies

Membership of the Board requires a country to consent to be bound by its charter, and it is offered on a rotational or a permanent basis. Gaza's civil administration is handled by the National Committee for the Administration of Gaza (NCAG), with Nickolay Mladenov as High Representative linking the Board and the NCAG on the ground. The Gaza Executive Board is a supporting operational body that coordinates on-the-ground activities.

- Membership requires a country to consent to be bound by the Charter
- Rotational membership: 3-year tenure without mandatory financial contribution
- Permanent membership: available through a reported contribution of USD 1 billion
- Initial authorisation of the Board lasts until 31 December 2027
- High Representative for Gaza: Bulgarian diplomat Nickolay Mladenov, on-the-ground liaison between Board and NCAG
- NCAG: 15-member committee of politically independent Palestinian technocrats
- NCAG is chaired by Ali Shaath, a former Palestinian Authority Deputy Minister
- NCAG is responsible for day-to-day civil administration
- Gaza Executive Board: supporting operational body that coordinates on-the-ground activities
- Gaza Executive Board members: US, UK, Turkey, Qatar, Egypt, UAE, Cyprus and Netherlands; no Palestinian representative

Mnemonic - Gaza bodies linked to the Board: Happy Newborn Giraffes

H = High Representative Nickolay Mladenov links the Board and the NCAG; N = NCAG, a 15-member committee for day-to-day civil administration; G = Gaza Executive Board coordinates on-the-ground activities

Mind-map outline

Membership and Gaza bodies

- Membership
 - Consent to be bound by Charter
 - Rotational: 3-year tenure
 - Permanent: reported USD 1 billion
- Initial authorisation

- Lasts until 31 December 2027
- High Representative
 - Nickolay Mladenov, Bulgarian diplomat
 - On-the-ground liaison: Board and NCAG
- NCAG
 - 15 politically independent technocrats
 - Chaired by Ali Shaath
 - Day-to-day civil administration
- Gaza Executive Board
 - Supporting operational body
 - 8 countries, no Palestinian representative

Key Features of the US 20-point Gaza Plan

The US plan, officially titled the Comprehensive Plan to End the Gaza Conflict, envisions a demilitarised Gaza with an immediate ceasefire and the release of all hostages. It pairs security arrangements, including the International Stabilization Force (ISF), with humanitarian aid and reconstruction through a special economic zone. The plan excludes Hamas from governance while offering amnesty to members who decommission their weapons.

- Gaza is envisioned as a demilitarised, terror-free zone
- An immediate ceasefire is mandated, halting military actions by both sides
- All hostages, alive or deceased, must be released within 72 hours of Israel's formal acceptance
- Israel frees 250 Palestinian life-sentence prisoners and 1,700 detainees
- Hamas members who decommission weapons get amnesty or safe passage abroad
- Full humanitarian aid enters immediately; Rafah crossing reopens under agreement
- Special economic zone with favourable trade terms, supported by international investment
- No forced displacement: people are free to stay, leave or return
- Hamas is excluded from governance; ISF deployed to secure Gaza and train police
- Interfaith dialogue platform created to promote religious harmony

Mnemonic - Five features of the plan: Dogs Chase Hungry Iguanas Everywhere

D = Demilitarised, terror-free zone for Gaza; C = Immediate ceasefire; H = Hostages released within 72 hours of Israel's acceptance; I = Interfaith dialogue platform; E = Special economic zone

Mind-map outline

US 20-point Gaza plan

- Security
 - Demilitarised, terror-free zone
 - Hamas excluded from governance
 - ISF secures Gaza and trains police
- Ceasefire and hostages
 - Immediate ceasefire
 - Hostages returned within 72 hours
 - Israel frees 250 life-sentence prisoners
- Aid and reconstruction
 - Full humanitarian aid
 - Rafah crossing reopens
 - Special economic zone
- Rights and governance
 - No forced displacement
 - Amnesty for members who decommission weapons
 - Interfaith dialogue platform

UN Reform and the Board's Significance

Reform of the UN system is treated as urgent because ad hoc peacebuilding missions end once crises subside and UN Security Council reform is deadlocked. The booklet presents the Board as an incremental innovation within existing structures, using the General Assembly's power under Article 22 of the UN Charter. The Board is also described as a move from universal multilateral institutions towards leader-centric mini-lateral mechanisms.

- UN peacebuilding missions often end once immediate crises subside
- Prolonged deadlock over comprehensive UNSC reform has paralysed timely action
- Under Article 22 of the UN Charter, the General Assembly can establish subsidiary bodies without Charter amendment
- Board of Peace is presented as reform from within, not replacement of the UNSC
- Board aims to institutionalise long-term political engagement and prevent relapse into conflict
- Represents a move from universal multilateral institutions to mini-lateral, leader-centric mechanisms
- Emphasises political authority, resource mobilisation and rapid decision-making over consensus-based diplomacy
- Projected as a template for managing complex global conflicts
- Signals evolving US thinking on conflict resolution and post-war governance

Mind-map outline

UN reform and Board significance

- Why reform is urgent
 - Ad hoc missions end when crises subside
 - UNSC reform deadlock
 - Fragmented peacebuilding
- Legal route
 - UN Charter Article 22
 - General Assembly can set up subsidiary bodies
- Board's approach
 - Reform from within, not replacement
 - Mini-lateral, leader-centric model
 - Rapid decisions over consensus
- Template
 - Model for complex global conflicts

Diego Garcia and the Chagos Islands

Sovereignty Deal and Diego Garcia Base

Britain has agreed to transfer sovereignty of the Chagos Islands to Mauritius, but the UK will retain sovereign rights over Diego Garcia. A joint UK-US military base there will remain operational for an initial period of 99 years. US concerns centre on strategic autonomy and base security, and Trump criticised the plan.

- Britain has agreed to transfer sovereignty of the Chagos Islands to Mauritius.
- The Chagos archipelago comprises 58 islands, with Diego Garcia the largest.
- The UK retains sovereign rights over Diego Garcia under the agreement.
- A joint UK-US military base on Diego Garcia will remain operational for an initial period of 99 years.
- Diego Garcia is located in the Central Indian Ocean.
- US concern: a sovereignty change may affect strategic autonomy and base security.
- Trump criticised the UK plan, citing the strategic importance of the US military base.
- The issue is sensitive because it pits decolonisation against security interests.

Mind-map outline

Sovereignty deal

- Chagos Islands to Mauritius
 - 58 islands in archipelago
 - Diego Garcia is largest
- UK keeps Diego Garcia rights
 - Joint UK-US military base
 - Initial period of 99 years

- Concerns and criticism
 - Strategic autonomy and base security
 - Trump cites strategic importance

Chagos Dispute and Legal Battles

The UK declared the Chagos Islands a British Indian Ocean Territory in 1965, and the islands stayed with Britain when Mauritius became independent in 1968. Between 1968 and 1973, native Chagossians were forcibly removed to make way for a military base. Mauritius then pursued legal routes, including a case at the Permanent Court of Arbitration and an ICJ advisory opinion that ended in a 2019 order to return the islands.

- The UK declared the Chagos Islands a British Indian Ocean Territory in 1965.
- Chagos remained with Britain when Mauritius gained independence in 1968.
- Between 1968 and 1973, the UK and US forcibly removed native Chagossians.
- In 2015, Mauritius initiated legal proceedings against the UK at the Permanent Court of Arbitration in The Hague.
- The Permanent Court of Arbitration ruled that the UK violated Mauritius' rights under UNCLOS.
- The Court found that the UK had ulterior motives in creating a Marine Protected Area around the Chagos Islands in 2010.
- The UK insisted that the issue should remain a bilateral matter.
- In 2017, the UNGA voted on Mauritius' resolution to seek an ICJ advisory opinion.
- In 2019, the ICJ ordered the UK to return the Chagos Islands to Mauritius.
- The UK claimed that the ICJ had no jurisdiction over the matter.

Mnemonic - Dispute milestones: Marine Parks Vanish Overnight

M = Marine Protected Area around Chagos created in 2010; P = PCA ruled UK violated Mauritius' rights (2015); V = UNGA voted on the advisory opinion resolution (2017); O = ICJ ordered UK to return the Chagos Islands (2019)

Mind-map outline

Chagos dispute

- BIOT declared in 1965
- Forced removal 1968-1973
- Legal route
 - PCA: UK violated UNCLOS (2015)
 - Marine Protected Area (2010)
 - UNGA vote on advisory opinion (2017)
 - ICJ ordered return (2019)

Colonial History of the Chagos Islands

Portuguese navigators discovered the Chagos Islands in the 16th century, and the islands later came under French control. After Napoleon's defeat, Britain took control of both Chagos and Mauritius, and France ceded the islands to Britain in 1814. Mauritius later argued that it had been coerced into giving up the islands, in violation of UN Resolution 1514.

- Portuguese navigators discovered the Chagos Islands in the 16th century.
- The Chagos Islands later came under French control.
- After Napoleon's defeat, Britain took control of both Chagos and Mauritius.
- In 1814, France ceded the islands to Britain.
- Mauritius argued that it was coerced into giving up the islands during colonial rule.
- UN Resolution 1514 prohibited the breakup of colonies before independence.
- The UK claimed that the ICJ had no jurisdiction over the matter.
- Mauritius is a former British and French colony that gained independence from British rule in 1968.

Mind-map outline

Colonial history of Chagos

- Portuguese discovery, 16th century
- Later French control
- British control after Napoleon
- France ceded islands in 1814

- Resolution 1514 argument

Mauritius and India Partnership

India and Mauritius established diplomatic relations in 1948, and the partnership now covers security, trade and culture. Mauritius is a key source of investment into India and a gateway for Indian trade into Africa. India has also supported Mauritius on security and disaster response, including naval drills and an airfield upgrade.

- Mauritius is an island nation in the Western Indian Ocean, with its capital at Port Louis.
- India and Mauritius established diplomatic relations in 1948.
- Mahatma Gandhi visited Mauritius in 1901.
- The Indira Gandhi Centre for Indian Culture (1987) is India's largest cultural centre abroad.
- The 2021 CECPA was the first such agreement between India and an African nation.
- Bilateral trade in FY 2024-25 was USD 887.25 million.
- Mauritius was the second largest source of FDI into India in FY 2024-25, after Singapore.
- India was the first responder for Mauritius during COVID-19, the Wakashio oil spill (2020) and Cyclone Chido.
- Mauritius participates in India-led VARUNA and MILAN naval drills.
- India upgraded the Agaléga Island airstrip into a full-length airfield.

Mind-map outline

India-Mauritius partnership

- Security
 - Coastal radar stations
 - VARUNA and MILAN drills
- Economy
 - CECPA signed in 2021
 - Second largest FDI source after Singapore
- Culture
 - Gandhi visit in 1901
 - Indira Gandhi Centre (1987)

MAHASAGAR and Maritime Initiatives

MAHASAGAR is an Indian Navy initiative launched in 2023 that builds on India's 2015 SAGAR maritime doctrine. It widens the focus from India's immediate neighbourhood to the broader Global South, with trade, security, technology and finance as key areas. New tools under it include the IOS Sagar platform and the AIKEYME naval exercise with African nations.

- MAHASAGAR builds on India's 2015 Maritime Doctrine, SAGAR.
- MAHASAGAR was launched by the Indian Navy in 2023.
- MAHASAGAR widens the scope of SAGAR from India's immediate maritime neighbourhood to the broader Global South.
- MAHASAGAR's key focus areas are trade for development, mutual security, technology sharing and financial assistance.
- MAHASAGAR is a bi-annual initiative that convenes naval chiefs and maritime officials from littoral states.
- IOS Sagar uses the INS Sunayna platform to deepen naval cooperation with Indian Ocean littorals.
- AIKEYME is a large-scale naval exercise with African nations.
- AIKEYME means Unity in Sanskrit, symbolising solidarity with African partners.

Mind-map outline

MAHASAGAR initiative

- Launched by Indian Navy in 2023
- Builds on SAGAR (2015)
- Focus areas
 - Trade for development
 - Mutual security
 - Technology sharing
 - Financial assistance
- New initiatives

- IOS Sagar with INS Sunayna
- AIKEYME naval exercise with Africa

UAE-Saudi Rift in Yemen

Mukalla Port airstrike and STC standoff

Saudi Arabia struck Mukalla Port and UAE-backed STC units after alleging an arms shipment for separatists, which Abu Dhabi denied. The STC refused Riyadh's call to withdraw from contested areas, and the UAE pulled its troops out of Saudi Arabia. The episode shows divisions within the anti-Houthi coalition despite shared opposition to the Houthis.

- Saudi Arabia carried out airstrikes on Mukalla Port in southern Yemen.
- The strike followed the arrival of a consignment from Fujairah (UAE).
- Riyadh alleged the consignment contained arms meant for southern separatist groups.
- Abu Dhabi said the shipment consisted of vehicles meant exclusively for UAE forces.
- Saudi aircraft also struck UAE-supported STC units, with strikes reported in Hadramout.
- Saudi-aligned National Shield Forces sought to take over STC military installations.
- Riyadh called for STC fighters to withdraw from contested areas; the STC refused.
- Saudi Arabia asked the UAE to withdraw its military elements within 24 hours.
- UAE cited escalating airstrikes as a security risk to its personnel.

Mnemonic - UAE withdrawal reasons: Safety, Mandate, Politics: SMP

Safety = Escalating airstrikes raised risks to UAE personnel; Mandate = UAE presence confined to counter-terrorism operations; Politics = Yemen's future political structure should be decided by Yemenis

Mind-map outline

Mukalla airstrike and STC standoff

- Saudi strikes
 - Mukalla Port
 - STC units in Hadramout
- Disputed shipment
 - Consignment from Fujairah (UAE)
 - Riyadh: arms for separatists
 - UAE: vehicles for its forces
- STC refusal
 - Withdrawal from contested areas refused
 - Expansion into Mahra

Yemen's North-South divide and Houthi insurgency

North and South Yemen were separate states until their 1990 merger, and centralised power after unification fuelled southern resentment. A secession attempt in 1994 and the Southern Movement formed in 2007 reflect this divide. The Houthi insurgency began in 2004, and the Houthis captured Sanaa in 2014.

- North and South Yemen differed in religious traditions, social structures and governance systems.
- Until 1990, Yemen existed as two states: the Yemeni Arab Republic (North) and the PDRY (South).
- The North was supported by the United States and Saudi Arabia; the South was backed by the Soviet Union.
- In 1990 the two states merged to form the Republic of Yemen under Ali Abdullah Saleh.
- Southern leaders attempted secession in 1994, leading to a brief civil conflict.
- The Southern Movement (Al-Hirak) formed in 2007 and demands greater autonomy or independence.
- Houthi insurgency began after Hussein al-Houthi, the movement's founder, was killed in Saada in 2004.
- Houthis captured Sanaa in 2014, forcing President Hadi to flee abroad in 2015.
- In 2017 the Houthis claimed a missile attack on Riyadh's King Khalid International Airport.

Mnemonic - Merger, split and Hirak dates: Merged Ninety, Split Ninety-Four, Hirak Oh-Seven

Ninety = 1990: the two Yemeni states merged; Ninety-Four = 1994: Southern leaders attempted secession; Oh-Seven = 2007: Southern Movement (Al-Hirak) formed

Mind-map outline

North-South divide and Houthis

- North-South divide
 - Cold War: two separate states
 - 1990 merger under Saleh
 - 1994 secession attempt
 - 2007 Al-Hirak formed
- Houthi insurgency
 - Founder killed in 2004
 - Captured Sanaa in 2014
 - 2017 missile claim on Riyadh airport

India-UAE partnership

India and the UAE agreed to double bilateral trade to over USD 200 billion by 2032. Their ties span energy, with a long-term LNG deal, civil nuclear cooperation and defence collaboration, along with a proposal for data embassies. The UAE also accounted for 18% of India's remittance flows.

- India and the UAE agreed to double bilateral trade to over USD 200 billion by 2032.
- Bilateral trade was US\$ 100 billion in FY 2024-25.
- The UAE is India's 3rd largest trade partner, after China and the US.
- In 2022, India became the first country with which the UAE signed a CEPA.
- ADNOC Gas signed an agreement with HPCL to supply 0.5 million tonnes per annum of LNG for 10 years.
- The UAE accounted for 18% of India's remittance flows.
- India has access to the UAE's Al Dhafra Air Base for refuelling.
- Both countries agreed to explore cooperation in small modular reactors and nuclear safety.
- A proposal for offshore digital infrastructure would store critical national data as data embassies.

Mnemonic - India-UAE trade numbers: Hundred now, two hundred by thirty-two

Hundred = USD 100 billion bilateral trade in FY 2024-25; Two hundred = Target of over USD 200 billion in bilateral trade; Thirty-two = Target year is 2032

Mind-map outline

India-UAE partnership

- Trade
 - Target USD 200bn by 2032
 - FY 2024-25: USD 100bn
- Energy and nuclear
 - LNG: 0.5 MTPA for 10 years
 - Small modular reactors
- Digital and defence
 - Data embassy proposal
 - Defence technology cooperation

UAE profile and the Kafala system

The UAE is a federal elective monarchy of seven emirates, with Abu Dhabi as its capital and the dirham as its currency. Under the Kafala system, an in-country sponsor, typically the employer, controls a migrant worker's visa and legal status. Workers cannot change jobs or leave the country without that sponsor's permission.

- The UAE is a federal elective monarchy composed of 7 emirates.
- The UAE shares land borders with Oman and Saudi Arabia.
- The UAE's maritime borders in the Persian Gulf are with Qatar and Iran.
- The UAE's capital is Abu Dhabi and its currency is the dirham.
- Mohammed bin Zayed Al Nahyan is the President; Mohammed bin Rashid Al Maktoum is the Prime Minister.
- Kafala means 'sponsorship' in Arabic.
- Under Kafala, an in-country sponsor, typically the employer, controls a worker's visa and legal status.
- Workers cannot change jobs or leave the country without the sponsor's permission.
- Kafala can lead to exploitation, non-payment of wages, poor conditions and restricted movement.
- Barakah is the Arab world's first nuclear power plant.

Mind-map outline

UAE profile and Kafala

- Geography and government
 - Federal elective monarchy, 7 emirates
 - Land borders with Oman and Saudi Arabia
- Leadership
 - President: Mohammed bin Zayed Al Nahyan
 - PM: Mohammed bin Rashid Al Maktoum
- Kafala system
 - Sponsor controls visa and legal status
 - No job change without sponsor permission

National News and Issues

Republic Day 2026

Republic Day 2026 Parade and Chronology

Republic Day celebrations begin on 23 January, observed as Parakram Divas, and conclude on 29 January with the Beating Retreat Ceremony at Vijay Chowk. The main events fall on 26 January, when the Prime Minister pays homage at the Amar Jawan Jyoti and the President unfurls the National Flag at Kartavya Path. The 2026 parade, the 77th Republic Day, showcased Constitutional values through 30 cultural tableaux.

- Festivities officially begin on 23 January, observed as Parakram Divas.
- 23 January marks the birth anniversary of Netaji Subhash Chandra Bose.
- The President delivers the Republic Day Address on the day before Republic Day.
- The Prime Minister pays homage at Amar Jawan Jyoti in early morning of 26 January.
- The President unfurls the National Flag at Kartavya Path (formerly Rajpath).
- The National Anthem and a 21-gun salute follow the flag unfurling and mark the formal start of the parade.
- The President confers Padma and Gallantry Awards in the evening of 26 January.
- Celebrations conclude on 29 January at Vijay Chowk with the Beating Retreat Ceremony.
- 2026 is India's 77th Republic Day; the theme is 150 Years of Vande Mataram.
- Top tableaux: Maharashtra, Jammu & Kashmir and Kerala; Chief Guests: Ursula von der Leyen and Antonio Costa.

Mind-map outline

Republic Day 2026 Events

- Before the parade
 - 23 Jan: Parakram Divas
 - Day before: President's Address
- On 26 January
 - Amar Jawan Jyoti homage
 - Flag unfurling at Kartavya Path
 - 21-gun salute
- After the parade
 - Evening: Padma and Gallantry Awards
 - 29 Jan: Beating Retreat, Vijay Chowk

Padma and Gallantry Awards

Padma Awards are announced every year on the eve of Republic Day and recognise achievements in all fields involving public service. Gallantry Awards honour bravery of armed forces personnel and are announced twice a year. The Padma Awards 2026 conferred 131 honours, and Shubhanshu Shukla received the Ashok Chakra.

- Padma Awards 2026 conferred 131 honours in total.
- The 2026 Padma list included 5 Padma Vibhushan, 13 Padma Bhushan and 113 Padma Shri.
- Padma Awards were instituted in 1954 and are announced annually on the eve of Republic Day.
- Padma categories in order of rank: Padma Vibhushan, then Padma Bhushan, then Padma Shri.
- Gallantry Awards were conferred on 70 Armed Forces personnel.

- Shubhanshu Shukla, the first Indian on the ISS, was honoured with the Ashok Chakra.
- Ashok Chakra is India's highest peacetime gallantry award.
- Gallantry Awards are announced twice a year, on Republic Day and Independence Day.
- Wartime Gallantry was instituted on 26 January 1950; Peacetime Gallantry in 1952.
- Gallantry eligibility covers officers of all ranks (Army, Navy, IAF), reserve forces, Territorial Army and nursing services.

Mnemonic - Padma Category Order: Very Bright Stars

V = Padma Vibhushan, the highest Padma category; B = Padma Bhushan, the second Padma category; S = Padma Shri, the third Padma category

Mind-map outline

Padma and Gallantry Awards

- Padma Awards
 - Instituted 1954
 - Announced on eve of Republic Day
 - Vibhushan > Bhushan > Shri
- Gallantry Awards
 - Wartime instituted 26 Jan 1950
 - Peacetime instituted 1952
 - Announced twice a year
- 2026 honours
 - 131 Padma honours
 - 70 armed forces gallantry awards

History of Republic Day

26 January was linked to the Poorna Swaraj declaration from the Lahore Session of the Indian National Congress in December 1929. From 1930 to 1947 the day was celebrated as Independence Day or Poorna Swaraj Day. The Constitution, adopted on 26 November 1949, came into effect on 26 January 1950, making India a sovereign democratic republic.

- The Lahore Session of INC in December 1929 passed the Poorna Swaraj resolution.
- Poorna Swaraj called for total self-rule, sovereignty and complete independence from British rule.
- The Declaration of Independence was officially promulgated on 26 January 1930.
- From 1930 to 1947, 26 January was celebrated as Independence Day or Poorna Swaraj Day.
- The Constitution was adopted by the Constituent Assembly on 26 November 1949.
- The Constitution came into effect on 26 January 1950.
- The Constitution repealed the Indian Independence Act 1947 and the Government of India Act 1935.
- India ceased to be a Dominion of the British Crown and became a Sovereign, Democratic Republic.
- India gained independence on 15 August 1947.
- 26 November has been observed as Constitution Day since 2015.

Mind-map outline

History of Republic Day

- 1929 to 1947
 - Poorna Swaraj resolution, Dec 1929
 - 26 Jan 1930: Declaration promulgated
 - 1930-1947: Independence / Poorna Swaraj Day
- 1947 to 1950
 - 15 Aug 1947: Independence
 - 26 Nov 1949: Constitution adopted
 - 26 Jan 1950: Constitution effective

Unfurling and Hoisting the Flag

On Republic Day the President unfurls the Tricolour, while on Independence Day the Prime Minister hoists it. The difference reflects the two events: unfurling renews commitment to Constitutional principles, and hoisting symbolises the rise of a new nation.

- On 26 January the President of India, as Head of State, unfurls the Tricolour.
- On 15 August the Prime Minister, who heads the Union Government, hoists the National Flag.
- On 26 January the flag is folded or rolled and attached to the top of a pole.
- The President unveils the flag without pulling it up.

- On 15 August the flag is positioned at the bottom of the pole and raised from bottom to top.
- Unfurling is a symbolic gesture to renew commitment to the principles of the Constitution.
- Unfurling highlights India's shift from a British colony to a Sovereign, Democratic Republic.
- Hoisting symbolises the rise of a new nation, patriotism and freedom from colonial rule.

Mnemonic - Who Unfurls and Who Hoists: Jan Unfurls, August Hoists

Jan = 26 January: the President unfurls the Tricolour; August = 15 August: the Prime Minister hoists the National Flag

Mind-map outline

Flag: Unfurling vs Hoisting

- 26 January
 - President unfurls the Tricolour
 - Flag attached to top of pole
 - Renews commitment to Constitution
- 15 August
 - PM hoists the National Flag
 - Flag raised from bottom to top
 - Symbolises rise of a new nation

UGC (Promotion of Equity in Higher Education Institutions) Regulations, 2026

University Grants Commission: Origin, Status and Functions

The University Grants Commission is a statutory body under the UGC Act, 1956, formally inaugurated in 1953 by Maulana Abul Kalam Azad. Its idea evolved from the Sargeant Report (1944), and the University Education Commission (1948) recommended restructuring it on the British model. The UGC allocates grants, advises the government on higher education reforms and maintains academic standards from its headquarters in New Delhi.

- Statutory body under the UGC Act, 1956
- Formally inaugurated in 1953 by Maulana Abul Kalam Azad
- Idea evolved from the Sargeant Report (1944)
- University Grants Committee set up in 1945, expanded by 1947 to oversee all Indian universities
- University Education Commission (1948) chaired by Dr. S. Radhakrishnan
- That Commission recommended restructuring UGC on the British model
- In 1952, the government entrusted UGC with oversight of higher education grants
- Functions: allocating grants, advising government, maintaining academic standards
- Composition: Chairman, Vice-Chairman and 10 members appointed by Central Government
- Headquarters: New Delhi

Mind-map outline

University Grants Commission

- Origins
 - Sargeant Report 1944
 - Grants Committee set up 1945
 - Radhakrishnan Commission 1948
- Functions
 - Allocating grants
 - Advising government
 - Maintaining academic standards
- Composition
 - Chairman and Vice-Chairman
 - 10 members, Central Government

Caste Discrimination and Legal Safeguards

UGC data show that caste-discrimination complaints rose by 118 per cent between 2019-20 and 2023-24, and pending cases grew sharply despite high disposal rates. Caste discrimination erodes equality, dignity and fraternity and limits SC, ST and OBC access to elite institutions.

Constitutional articles and statutes such as the Protection of Civil Rights Act, 1955 and the SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989 provide the legal safeguards.

- Caste-discrimination complaints rose 118%, from 173 (2019-20) to 378 (2023-24)

- Pending caste-discrimination cases rose from 18 to 108 over the same period, despite high disposal rates
- Rohith Vemula (2016) and Payal Tadvi (2019) cases spotlight alleged institutional caste exclusion
- Caste discrimination erodes equality, dignity and fraternity
- Caste bias and poor schooling limit SC/ST/OBC access to elite institutions
- Marginalised groups face higher dropout rates due to academic, financial and psychological pressures
- SC/ST cells in universities often lack autonomy and enforcement
- Article 14: equality before law; Article 15: prohibits discrimination and allows affirmative action; Article 17: abolishes untouchability
- Protection of Civil Rights Act, 1955; SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989; Right to Education Act, 2009

Mnemonic - Articles 14, 15 and 17: Equal Allies Abolish

Equal = Article 14: equality before law; Allies = Article 15: prohibits discrimination and allows affirmative action; Abolish = Article 17: abolishes untouchability

Mind-map outline

Caste discrimination in universities

- Status
 - Complaints 173 to 378
 - Pending cases 18 to 108
- Impact
 - Higher dropout rates
 - Stigma and anxiety
 - Weak SC/ST cells
- Legal safeguards
 - Articles 14, 15, 17
 - Civil Rights Act 1955
 - Right to Education Act 2009

Key Provisions of the 2026 Regulations

The 2026 Regulations define caste-based discrimination broadly, covering direct, indirect and systemic discrimination, and aim to prevent discrimination on campuses. Equal Opportunity Centres, which are mandatory in all higher education institutions, house Equity Committees that must act on complaints within set timelines. Institutions face reporting duties, and non-compliance can lead to penalties such as debarment from UGC schemes.

- Caste-based discrimination is defined to include unfair or biased treatment
- Covers direct, indirect and systemic discrimination
- Prevents discrimination on campuses based on caste, religion, gender, race, disability or place of birth
- Equal Opportunity Centres: nodal body, mandatory in all higher education institutions
- Equity Committee: Head as Chairperson; 3 senior faculty, 1 non-teaching staff, 2 civil society and 2 student representatives; EOC coordinator as Member Secretary
- Equity Committee convenes within 24 hours of a complaint; inquiry report due within 15 working days
- Ombudsperson: independent authority for appeals against unresolved equity grievances; decisions binding on institutions
- EOCs submit bi-annual reports; institutions submit annual equity compliance reports; National Monitoring Committee meets at least twice a year
- Non-compliance can lead to debarment from UGC schemes, restrictions on offering degrees, or withdrawal of UGC recognition

Mnemonic - Penalties for non-compliance: Don't Risk Withdrawal

D = Debarment from UGC schemes; R = Restrictions on offering degrees; W = Withdrawal of UGC recognition

Mind-map outline

2026 Equity Regulations

- Equity Committee
 - Head is Chairperson
 - 3 senior faculty, 2 student reps
 - EOC coordinator is Member Secretary

- Timelines
 - Convene within 24 hours
 - Inquiry report in 15 working days
- Compliance
 - EOC bi-annual reports
 - Institution annual compliance reports
 - Monitoring committee twice a year
- Penalties
 - Debarment from UGC schemes
 - Restrictions on offering degrees
 - Withdrawal of UGC recognition

Concerns Raised About the Regulations

Critics fear the framework could indirectly influence the social and demographic composition of campuses. They point to the absence of safeguards against false or malicious complaints and to the lack of confidentiality or timely redress for the accused. Short inquiry periods and the automatic linkage of the helpline to police are also seen as risks.

- Demographic policing concerns: may indirectly influence the social and demographic composition of campuses
- No explicit protection against false, frivolous or malicious complaints
- No mechanisms for confidentiality or timely redress for the accused; risk of reputational damage
- Compressed inquiry timelines may compromise fact-finding and increase the risk of errors
- Helpline's automatic linkage to police may discourage open academic discourse and reporting
- Students and faculty could fear criminal consequences

Mnemonic - Concerns about the regulations: Dark Alleys Really Confuse Crowds

D = Demographic policing concerns; A = Absence of safeguards against false complaints; R = Risk of reputational damage to the accused; C = Compressed inquiry timelines; C = Criminal escalation through police linkage

Mind-map outline

Opposition to the regulations

- Campus composition
 - Demographic policing concern
- Fairness
 - No protection from false complaints
 - Risk of reputational damage
- Process
 - Compressed inquiry timelines
 - Police linkage deters reporting

Polity and Governance

10 Years of Startup India Initiative

Launch, Aim and Management

The Startup India Initiative was launched on 16 January 2016 to foster startup culture and build an inclusive ecosystem for innovation and entrepreneurship. The Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade, under the Ministry of Commerce & Industry, manages it. 16 January is observed as National Startup Day, and India marks 10 years of the initiative.

- Launched on 16 January 2016.
- Aim: foster startup culture and build an inclusive ecosystem for innovation and entrepreneurship.
- Managed by the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT), Ministry of Commerce & Industry.
- 16 January is observed as National Startup Day.
- India ranks as the world's third largest startup hub, after the US and China.
- Unicorn: a startup with potential to reach a valuation of 1 billion dollars in the near future.
- Decacorn: valuation of 10 billion dollars.

- Hectocorn: valuation of 100 billion dollars.

Mind-map outline

Startup India Launch

- Launched 16 Jan 2016
 - National Startup Day on 16 Jan
- Aim: startup culture and inclusive ecosystem
- Managed by DPIIT
 - Ministry of Commerce & Industry

Eligibility and Core Features

A startup qualifies if it is headquartered in India, opened less than 10 years ago and has an annual turnover below 100 crore. The initiative offers ease of doing business through self-certification and single-window clearances. Eligible startups also enjoy tax exemptions for three consecutive financial years.

- A startup must be an entity headquartered in India.
- It must have opened less than 10 years ago.
- Annual turnover must be less than 100 crore.
- Ease of doing business through simplified compliance, self-certification and single-window clearances.
- Eligible startups enjoy tax exemptions for 3 consecutive financial years.
- Sector-specific policies target biotechnology, agriculture and renewable energy.
- Funding support includes a 10,000 crore Fund of Funds for early-stage funding.

Mnemonic - Core features: Every Team Finds Success

E = Ease of doing business through simplified compliance and single-window clearances; T = Tax exemptions for 3 consecutive financial years; F = Funding support, including the 10,000 crore Fund of Funds; S = Sector-specific policies for biotechnology, agriculture and renewable energy

Mind-map outline

Startup Eligibility and Features

- Eligibility
 - Headquartered in India
 - Opened under 10 years ago
 - Turnover below 100 crore
- Core features
 - Ease of doing business
 - Tax exemption for 3 years
 - Funding support
 - Sector-specific policies

Funding Support Schemes

Startup India funding support works through the Seed Fund Scheme, the Credit Guarantee Scheme and the Fund of Funds for Startups. The Fund of Funds was introduced in June 2016 with a corpus of 10,000 crore to enhance access to domestic capital. Seed assistance covers early activities such as proof of concept and market entry, delivered through eligible incubators.

- Seed Fund Scheme provides financial assistance for proof of concept, prototype development, product trials, market entry and commercialization.
- Seed Fund assistance is delivered through eligible incubators.
- Credit Guarantee Scheme offers credit guarantees for loans to DPIIT-recognized startups.
- Fund of Funds for Startups was introduced in June 2016.
- Fund of Funds corpus is 10,000 crore.
- Fund of Funds aims to enhance access to domestic capital.
- Fund of Funds supports early-stage funding.

Mnemonic - Funding schemes: Seeds Grow Funds

S = Seed Fund Scheme for proof of concept and prototype development; G = Credit Guarantee Scheme for loans to DPIIT-recognized startups; F = Fund of Funds for Startups with a 10,000 crore corpus

Mind-map outline

Funding Support

- Seed Fund Scheme

- Proof of concept and prototypes
- Market entry and commercialization
- Credit Guarantee Scheme
 - Loans to DPIIT-recognized startups
- Fund of Funds
 - Introduced June 2016
 - Corpus 10,000 crore

Incubation and Innovation Schemes

Several schemes support startups through incubation, technology focus and regional reach. Atal Incubation Centres, set up under the Atal Innovation Mission of NITI Aayog, provide physical infrastructure. TIDE 2.0, GENESIS, NIDHI and ASPIRE target emerging technologies, Tier-II and Tier-III cities, technology-driven ideas and agro-industry respectively.

- Atal Innovation Mission operates under NITI Aayog.
- Atal Innovation Mission establishes Atal Incubation Centres that provide physical infrastructure and support to startups.
- TIDE 2.0 stands for Technology Incubation and Development of Entrepreneurs.
- TIDE 2.0 supports startups in emerging technologies such as AI, IoT and Blockchain.
- GENESIS 2024 stands for Gen-Next Support for Innovative Startups.
- GENESIS aims to boost startups in Tier-II and Tier-III cities.
- NIDHI stands for National Initiative for Developing and Harnessing Innovations.
- NIDHI aims at socio-economic growth through wealth and job creation.
- ASPIRE stands for A Scheme for Promotion of Innovation, Rural Industries and Entrepreneurship.
- ASPIRE sets up a network of technology centres and incubation centres and promotes startups in agro-industry.

Mnemonic - Incubation schemes: Tiny Genes Nurture Aspirations

T = TIDE 2.0 supports startups in emerging technologies; G = GENESIS boosts startups in Tier-II and Tier-III cities; N = NIDHI turns technology-driven ideas into successful startups; A = ASPIRE promotes startups in agro-industry

Mind-map outline

Incubation and Innovation Schemes

- AIM under NITI Aayog
 - Atal Incubation Centres
- TIDE 2.0
 - AI, IoT and Blockchain
- GENESIS 2024
 - Tier-II and Tier-III cities
- NIDHI
 - Wealth and job creation
- ASPIRE
 - Agro-industry network

Mentorship, Networking and Events

BHASKAR connects startups, investors and mentors to empower non-metro cities, while MAARG offers intelligent matchmaking between mentors and startups. Startup Mahakumbh is a flagship event bringing together startups, unicorns, soonicorns, investors, industry leaders and ecosystem stakeholders. The fifth edition is scheduled in March in New Delhi.

- BHASKAR stands for Bharat Startup Knowledge Access Registry; it is the BHASKAR Platform of 2024.
- BHASKAR connects startups, investors and mentors.
- BHASKAR aims to empower non-metro cities.
- MAARG stands for Mentorship, Advisory, Assistance, Resilience & Growth.
- MAARG offers intelligent matchmaking between mentors and startups.
- Startup Mahakumbh is a flagship event bringing together startups, unicorns, soonicorns, investors, industry leaders and ecosystem stakeholders.
- The 5th Startup Mahakumbh is scheduled in March in New Delhi.

Mind-map outline

Mentorship and Networking

- BHASKAR (2024)
 - Connects startups, investors, mentors
- MAARG
 - Matchmaking mentors and startups
- Startup Mahakumbh
 - 5th edition, New Delhi, March

Economics

India-EU Free Trade Agreement

Deal Background and Significance

India and the EU concluded the India-EU Broad-based Trade and Investment Agreement, finalised at the 16th India-EU Summit in New Delhi. The deal closes nearly two decades of intermittent negotiations and is widely described as the 'Mother of All Deals'. It still awaits ratification by the Indian Parliament and European bodies before full implementation.

- Concluded by PM Modi and EU President Ursula von der Leyen
- Finalised at the 16th India-EU Summit, New Delhi
- Makes the EU India's 22nd Free Trade Agreement partner
- Officially the Broad-based Trade and Investment Agreement (BTIA)
- Negotiations began in 2007, suspended in 2013, revived in 2022
- Supports India's trade diversification and China-plus-one strategy
- Counters rising global trade protectionism, especially from the US
- Creates an economic space for two billion people

Tariff Cuts and Market Access

Duties on over 90% of bilateral trade have been removed under the agreement. The EU will eliminate customs duties on 99.5% of Indian exports, while India will phase out tariffs on over 90% of EU goods. High-value sectors such as cars and wines are opened gradually through staged tariff cuts and quotas.

- Duties on over 90% of bilateral trade removed
- EU eliminates customs duties on 99.5% of Indian exports
- Estimated \$33 billion boost to labour-intensive sectors
- Textiles and apparel, leather and footwear, gems and jewellery enter EU at 0% duty
- India phases out tariffs on over 90% of EU goods
- Machinery up to 44%, chemicals up to 22%, pharmaceuticals up to 11%
- EU exporters to save approximately EUR 4 billion annually
- Luxury car tariff (cars above EUR 15,000) falls from 110% to 10% in 5 years
- Tariff rate quota of 250,000 cars per year
- Premium wine tariffs fall from 150% to 20-30%; spirits to 40%

Protections, Exclusions and CBAM

Both sides keep negative lists of sensitive farm goods to protect rural livelihoods and food security. A parallel agreement protects geographical indications such as Darjeeling Tea and Champagne. The EU's Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism applies a carbon levy on selected imports from 1 January 2026, and India received a most-favoured-nation assurance on it without a full exemption.

- India's exclusions: dairy, wheat, rice and poultry
- EU's exclusions: beef, sugar and rice
- Geographical indication protection for Darjeeling Tea and Champagne
- EUR 500 million pledged for decarbonisation of Indian industries
- CBAM full implementation with carbon levy from 1 January 2026
- Transitional phase 2023-2025 involved reporting only, with no financial levy
- CBAM sectors: cement, aluminium, fertilisers, iron and steel, hydrogen, electricity
- CBAM certificate price linked to the EU ETS carbon price

- Credit allowed if a carbon tax was already paid in the exporting country
- India got an MFN assurance on CBAM but no full exemption

2030 Roadmap and the US Factor

The 'Towards 2030' Joint India-EU Comprehensive Strategic Agenda is a five-year framework adopted at the 16th Summit to move ties beyond trade. It is organised into pillars covering prosperity, technology, security, connectivity, and enablers such as skills and mobility. The deal is also framed as a hedge against US tariff policy, after 50% reciprocal tariffs on Indian goods were imposed in August 2025.

- Official title: 'Towards 2030: Joint India-EU Comprehensive Strategic Agenda'
- A five-year framework adopted at the 16th India-EU Summit
- Prosperity and Sustainability pillar includes green hydrogen and carbon market alignment
- Technology and Innovation pillar includes Trade and Technology Council and 6G, semiconductors, quantum
- Security and Defence pillar focuses on maritime security in the Indo-Pacific
- Connectivity pillar includes IMEC and the EU's Global Gateway initiative
- Enablers pillar covers skills and mobility, with a European Legal Gateway in India
- Mutual recognition of professional qualifications targeted by 2030
- 50% reciprocal tariffs on Indian goods imposed in August 2025
- Described as creating a 'Third Pole' in global trade

EU Basics and India-EU Ties

The European Union is a political and economic union of 27 member states, and it traces its origins to the European Coal and Steel Community formed in 1951 by six countries. Its key institutions include the Commission, Parliament, Council, Court of Justice and the European Central Bank. India and the EU have had diplomatic relations since 1962, and ties were upgraded to a Strategic Partnership in 2004.

- EU is a political and economic union of 27 member states
- Began as the European Coal and Steel Community (1951) with six founding members
- European Commission: executive body that proposes laws and manages the budget
- European Parliament: the EU's only elected legislative body
- European Council: heads of state or government, sets political direction
- Court of Justice of the EU ensures uniform application of EU law
- Diplomatic relations with the European Economic Community established in 1962
- Upgraded to a Strategic Partnership at The Hague Summit in 2004
- EU is India's largest trading partner in goods and largest foreign investor
- Bilateral trade in 2024-25 was \$136.53 billion

Reports, Summits, Indices

China's Population Decline

Demographic Winter: Meaning and Key Indicators

Demographic winter is a persistent and structural decline in population growth, and it is no longer limited to developed countries. Its key indicators are fertility below the replacement level of 2.1 and an inverted population pyramid with a rising old-age dependency ratio. It can lead to a shrinking workforce, a rising fiscal burden from ageing and a potential loss of the demographic dividend.

- Demographic winter: a persistent and structural decline in population growth.
- Now a global phenomenon, not limited to developed countries.
- Fertility rate below replacement level of 2.1 children per woman.
- Inverted population pyramid: shrinking young population and expanding elderly population.
- Rising old-age dependency ratio is a key indicator.
- Demographic dividend: growth potential from a larger working-age population compared to dependents.

- Total fertility rate (TFR) is the average births per woman; 2.1 is the replacement level.
- Fertility refers to children born to a woman during reproductive years (ages 15-49).

Mind-map outline

Demographic Winter

- Key indicators
 - TFR below 2.1
 - Inverted population pyramid
 - Rising old-age dependency ratio
- Demographic dividend
 - Larger working-age population
 - Growth potential
- Key terms
 - Replacement level 2.1
 - Fertility: ages 15-49

Causes and Negative Impacts of Demographic Winter

Causes include delayed life milestones, urbanisation, societal and cultural shifts, and greater access to family planning. A declining population brings a shrinking workforce, pressure on pension and healthcare systems, and greater isolation of the elderly. Developed nation trends suggest that a rebound is unlikely once fertility falls below the replacement level.

- Delayed milestones: later marriages and parenthood due to career priorities, economic insecurity and high housing and education costs.
- Urbanisation: smaller and costlier urban housing discourages larger families.
- Societal shifts: greater female workforce participation, preference for smaller families and changing family norms.
- Access to family planning gives greater reproductive autonomy and reduces unintended births.
- Shrinking workforce threatens future labour supply as youth replacement falls short over time.
- Ageing population raises the burden on healthcare, elderly care and pension systems.
- Low-fertility states face youth shortages; high-fertility states struggle with overpopulation.
- Smaller families disrupt traditional support systems, leading to greater elderly isolation.
- Declining fertility and late marriages are linked to social isolation and mental health challenges.
- Developed nation trends show that a rebound is unlikely once rates fall below replacement level.

Mnemonic - Causes of demographic winter: Dogs Usually Sleep Anywhere

D = Delayed life milestones; U = Urbanisation; S = Societal and cultural shifts; A = Access to family planning

Mind-map outline

Demographic Winter Causes and Impacts

- Causes
 - Delayed life milestones
 - Urbanisation and costly housing
 - Societal and cultural shifts
 - Access to family planning
- Impacts
 - Shrinking workforce
 - Pension and healthcare burden
 - Elderly isolation

China's Birth Control Policy: Timeline

China's approach moved from birth control being a minor priority under Mao Zedong to a central policy push in the 1970s. The One-Child Policy (1980) restricted most couples to a single child, and it was later replaced by a Two-Child Policy and a Three-Child Policy (2021). Fertility rates did not rebound despite these relaxations.

- Pre-1970s (Mao Zedong era): birth control existed but was not a major policy priority.
- Great Leap Forward (1958-62) aimed to boost production and living standards but resulted in famine and millions of deaths.
- Population growth rebounded after the Great Leap Forward was rolled back.
- 1970s five-year plans promoted birth control, often through coercive measures.

- Slogan 'Later, Longer, Fewer' encouraged delayed marriages, longer intervals between births and fewer children.
- One-Child Policy (1980) formally restricted most couples to a single child.
- The One-Child Policy aimed to curb rapid population growth and ease pressure on resources.
- Three-Child Policy introduced in 2021.
- Fertility rates have not rebounded despite the relaxations.

Mind-map outline

China's Birth Control Policy

- Pre-1970s
 - Mao era: not a major priority
- 1958-62
 - Great Leap Forward: famine
- 1970s
 - Later, Longer, Fewer slogan
- 1980 to 2021
 - One-Child Policy (1980)
 - Two-Child Policy (2016)
 - Three-Child Policy (2021)

Reasons for China's Population Decline

China's total fertility rate fell to 1.3 births per woman in the 2020 Census, far below the replacement level of 2.1. The One-Child Policy is credited with cutting the TFR from 2.75 in 1979, but fertility did not rebound after later relaxations. Female education, changing family norms, economic pressures and the COVID-19 pandemic are cited as further causes.

- TFR declined to 1.3 births per woman (2020 Census), far below the replacement level of 2.1.
- The One-Child Policy is credited with reducing TFR from 2.75 (1979) to 1.3 (2020).
- Fertility did not rebound after the Two-Child (2016) and Three-Child (2021) relaxations.
- The lack of rebound indicates deep-rooted behavioural and socio-economic shifts.
- Higher female education and employment have enhanced women's autonomy over reproductive decisions.
- Growing disengagement from traditional family structures has reduced pressure to marry early or have many children.
- Intense job competition, high urban living costs and work-life imbalance discourage marriage and childbearing.
- Housing pressures and economic uncertainty discourage fertility, especially among younger generations.
- COVID-19 related mortality and economic uncertainty further accelerated the population decline.
- Delayed childbirth and smaller family sizes follow from higher education and employment of women.

Mind-map outline

Reasons for Decline

- Fertility
 - TFR 2.75 in 1979
 - TFR 1.3 in 2020
- Social shifts
 - Female education and jobs
 - Weaker traditional family norms
- Economic pressure
 - Job competition
 - High urban living costs
 - Work-life imbalance
- Shocks
 - COVID-19 mortality and uncertainty

Global and Indian Fertility Context

UNFPA's State of World Population 2025 reports a global TFR of 2.25 in 2024, projected to reach the replacement level by 2050. India's fertility rate in 2025 was 1.9, below replacement, with wide regional differences. National schemes such as the National Population Policy 2000, ASHA workers and Janani Suraksha Yojana focus on voluntary choice, institutional deliveries and maternal and child health.

- UNFPA was founded in 1969 as the United Nations Fund for Population Activities and renamed in 1987.
- Global TFR was 2.25 in 2024 and is projected to hit replacement level of 2.1 by 2050.
- Highest TFR: Niger > Somalia > DR Congo; lowest TFR: South Korea < Hong Kong < Singapore.
- Elderly (65+) share of population: Japan 30%, Europe 20%, India 7%.
- India's fertility rate in 2025 was 1.9, below the replacement level of 2.1.
- India's working-age population (15-64 years) is 68%.
- Above-replacement states: Bihar (2.98) > Meghalaya > UP > Jharkhand > Manipur.
- National Population Policy 2000 aimed at replacement-level fertility (TFR 2.1) through voluntary choice.
- Janani Suraksha Yojana encourages institutional deliveries and provides free delivery, transport and postnatal care.
- Proposal to raise the legal age of marriage for girls to 21 years under the Prohibition of Child Marriage Act 2006.

Mnemonic - Above-replacement Indian states: Big Men Use Jeeps Mostly

B = Bihar (2.98), listed first; M = Meghalaya; U = UP, listed third; J = Jharkhand; M = Manipur, listed last

Mind-map outline

Global and Indian Fertility

- Global
 - UNFPA founded 1969
 - Global TFR 2.25 in 2024
 - Replacement level by 2050
- India
 - TFR 1.9 in 2025
 - Working-age share 68%
 - Bihar highest above replacement
- Schemes
 - National Population Policy 2000
 - ASHA workers
 - Janani Suraksha Yojana

Environment and Biodiversity

UN High Seas Treaty Enters Into Force

BBNJ Agreement: scope and objectives

The UN High Seas Treaty, also called the BBNJ Agreement, is a legally binding treaty for ocean spaces beyond national jurisdiction. It was negotiated under a UN-led intergovernmental conference and aims to safeguard biodiversity in these areas. It contributes to the Kunming-Montreal Global Biodiversity Framework, which targets 30% protection of land and sea by 2030.

- Also called UN High Seas Treaty; adopted in 2023.
- Legally binding international treaty governing ocean spaces beyond national jurisdiction.
- Covers the high seas and the International Seabed Area.
- These areas are global commons, open to all states for navigation, overflight, submarine cables and pipelines.
- Third implementing agreement under UNCLOS, alongside the 1994 Part XI Agreement and the 1995 UN Fish Stocks Agreement.
- Core objective: safeguard biodiversity in areas beyond national jurisdiction.

- Contributes to the Kunming-Montreal Global Biodiversity Framework.
- Four pillars: Marine Genetic Resources, Area-Based Management Tools, Environmental Impact Assessments, Capacity Building and Technology Transfer.
- Conference of the Parties (COP) is the decision-making body.
- Ratified by 83 countries; India has signed, ratification pending.

Mnemonic - Four BBNJ pillars: Many Apples Enrich Crops

M = Marine Genetic Resources; A = Area-Based Management Tools; E = Environmental Impact Assessments; C = Capacity Building and Technology Transfer

Mind-map outline

BBNJ Agreement

- Scope
 - High seas
 - International Seabed Area
- Objectives
 - Safeguard biodiversity
 - Supports Kunming-Montreal framework
- Governance
 - COP is decision-making body

UNCLOS and maritime zones

The 1982 UN Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS) sets the legal framework for all activities in the oceans and seas and is called the constitution for the oceans. It divides ocean space into zones with different levels of state control, from full sovereignty in the territorial sea to free navigation on the high seas. It also created three international institutions.

- UNCLOS (1982) is also called the constitution for the oceans.
- It has 168 parties and sets out the legal framework for all activities in the oceans and seas.
- The Convention created three new institutions at the international level.
- International Tribunal for the Law of the Sea: independent judicial body for disputes on interpretation or application of the Convention.
- International Seabed Authority: ensures protection of the marine environment from harmful effects of deep-seabed activities.
- Commission on the Limits of the Continental Shelf: facilitates establishing outer limits of the continental shelf beyond 200 NM from baselines.
- Territorial sea: the state has full sovereignty.
- Exclusive Economic Zone: extends to 200 NM; the state has the right to exploit all economic resources.
- High seas: free for navigation by vessels of all nations.
- 1 NM (nautical mile) = 1.852 km.

Mnemonic - UNCLOS bodies: Tigers Seek Cover

T = International Tribunal for the Law of the Sea (ITLOS); S = International Seabed Authority (ISA); C = Commission on the Limits of the Continental Shelf (CLCS)

Mind-map outline

UNCLOS (1982)

- Institutions
 - ITLOS
 - International Seabed Authority
 - CLCS
- Zones
 - Territorial sea: full sovereignty
 - EEZ: up to 200 NM
 - High seas: free navigation
- Facts
 - 168 parties
 - 1 NM = 1.852 km

Fisheries sector in India and its schemes

India's fisheries sector contributes 7.43% to agriculture gross value added, the highest among agriculture and allied sectors. India ranks high globally as a producer, aquaculture producer and exporter. Government schemes such as Pradhan Mantri Matsya Sampada Yojana aim to modernise the sector and support fish farmers and micro and small enterprises.

- Total fish output (2024-25): 197.75 lakh tonnes.
- Fisheries contribute 7.43% to agriculture GVA, the highest among agriculture and allied sectors.
- India is the 2nd largest producer (8% of world production) and 2nd largest aquaculture producer.
- India is the 4th largest exporter; the United States is the largest importer of Indian seafood.
- Pradhan Mantri Matsya Sampada Yojana was introduced in 2020 under the Atma Nirbhar Bharat Package.
- Matsya Sampada investment: Rs 20,050 crore.
- National Fisheries Development Board, established 2006, works under the Ministry of Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying.
- PM Matsya Kisan Samridhi Sah-Yojana: sub-scheme for fisheries micro and small enterprises, investment Rs 6,000 crore.
- Implementation period of the Sah-Yojana: 2023-24 to 2026-27.
- India's first riverine dolphin estimation counted 6,327 dolphins across 28 rivers in 8 states.

Mind-map outline

Fisheries in India

- Output and rank
 - 197.75 lakh tonnes (2024-25)
 - 7.43% of agriculture GVA
 - 2nd largest producer
- Schemes
 - PM Matsya Sampada Yojana (2020)
 - PM Matsya Kisan Samridhi Sah-Yojana
- Trade
 - 4th largest exporter
 - US largest importer

WTO Agreement on Fisheries Subsidies

The WTO Agreement on Fisheries Subsidies was adopted at the 12th Ministerial Conference in 2022 and entered into force in September 2025. It aims to set binding rules to curb harmful fisheries subsidies, especially those linked to illegal fishing. India did not join the agreement, citing the need to protect small fishers, livelihoods and food security.

- Adopted at the 12th Ministerial Conference, 2022.
- Entered into force in September 2025, after approval by two-thirds of members.
- Objective: establish binding rules to curb harmful fisheries subsidies.
- Prohibited: subsidies linked to Illegal, Unreported and Unregulated (IUU) fishing.
- Prohibited: subsidies for fishing on overfished stocks.
- Prohibited: support for fishing in unregulated high seas.
- Members must submit fisheries-related data.
- Supports SDG 14: conserve and sustainably use oceans, seas and marine resources.
- India did not join, citing the need to protect small fishers, livelihoods and food security.
- WTO Fish Fund provides aid to developing and LDC members for implementation.

Mind-map outline

WTO Fisheries Subsidies Agreement

- Status
 - Adopted 2022
 - In force September 2025
- Prohibited
 - Linked to IUU fishing
 - Overfished stocks
 - Unregulated high seas
- India

- Did not join
- Protect small fishers

Space

PSLV-C62 Mission Failure

PSLV-C62 failure and its cause

ISRO's first launch of 2026, PSLV-C62, was scheduled from Sriharikota in Andhra Pradesh. A third-stage solid rocket anomaly disrupted high-thrust delivery to the upper stages, which affected the intended satellite orbital injection. The failure came 8 months after the PSLV-C61 setback.

- Mission was ISRO's first launch of 2026
- Scheduled liftoff from Sriharikota, Andhra Pradesh
- Fault: 3rd-stage solid rocket anomaly
- Effect: high-thrust delivery to upper stages disrupted
- Impact: intended satellite orbital injection affected
- Failure came 8 months after the PSLV-C61 setback

Mind-map outline

PSLV-C62 failure

- Launch
 - ISRO's first launch of 2026
 - Sriharikota, Andhra Pradesh
- Anomaly
 - Third-stage solid rocket
 - High-thrust delivery to upper stages disrupted
- Impact
 - Intended satellite orbital injection affected
- Repeat
 - Followed PSLV-C61 setback
 - 8 months later

PSLV rocket profile and history

The Polar Satellite Launch Vehicle is called the Workhorse of ISRO and is a four-stage medium-lift launcher, first launched in 1993. It uses solid propellants in its first and third stages and liquid propellants in its second (Vikas engine) and fourth stages. It can carry up to 1750 kg to a 600 km Sun-synchronous orbit.

- Nickname: Workhorse of ISRO
- Type: four-stage medium-lift launch vehicle
- Launched in 1993; first success in 1994 with IRS-P2
- Stages 1 and 3 use solid propellants
- Stages 2 (Vikas engine) and 4 use liquid propellants
- First Indian launch vehicle equipped with liquid stages
- Payload: up to 1750 kg to a 600 km Sun-synchronous orbit
- Record: 104 satellites in one launch (2017)
- Notable missions: Chandrayaan-1, Mars Orbiter Mission, Aditya-L1, AstroSat

Mnemonic - PSLV stage pattern: Silly Lions Sing Loud

S = Stage 1 uses solid propellants; L = Stage 2 uses liquid propellants (Vikas engine); S = Stage 3 uses solid propellants; L = Stage 4 uses liquid propellants

Mind-map outline

PSLV profile

- Identity
 - Workhorse of ISRO
 - Four-stage medium-lift launcher
 - Launched in 1993
- Propulsion
 - Solid: stages 1 and 3

- Liquid: stage 2 (Vikas) and stage 4
- Capability
 - Up to 1750 kg
 - 600 km Sun-synchronous orbit
- Milestones
 - First success: 1994, IRS-P2
 - Record: 104 satellites, 2017

PSLV-C62 payloads

PSLV-C62 carried EOS-N1 (Anvesha), a hyperspectral imaging satellite developed for DRDO's Strategic Applications, and KID, a small re-entry prototype from a Spanish startup. It also carried AayulSAT, India's first on-orbit satellite refuelling payload. In total, 18 co-passenger satellites flew on the mission.

- EOS-N1 (Anvesha): hyperspectral imaging satellite
- EOS-N1 developed for DRDO's Strategic Applications
- EOS-N1 intended orbit: Sun-synchronous orbit
- KID (Kestrel Initial Demonstrator): small-scale re-entry vehicle prototype
- KID developed by a Spanish startup
- KID mission: re-entry and splashdown in the South Pacific Ocean
- AayulSAT: India's 1st on-orbit satellite refuelling payload
- AayulSAT developed by Bengaluru-based OrbitAID Aerospace
- 18 co-passenger satellites (domestic and international)
- Commercial payloads from India, Mauritius, Luxembourg, UAE, Singapore, Europe and the US

Mnemonic - PSLV-C62 key payloads: Every Kite Arrives

E = EOS-N1 (Anvesha), a hyperspectral imaging satellite; K = KID, a re-entry prototype from a Spanish startup; A = AayulSAT, India's first on-orbit satellite refuelling payload

Mind-map outline

PSLV-C62 payloads

- Earth observation
 - EOS-N1 Anvesha
 - Hyperspectral imaging
 - Sun-synchronous orbit
- Re-entry
 - KID from a Spanish startup
 - South Pacific splashdown
- Refuelling
 - AayulSAT by OrbitAID Aerospace
 - India's first on-orbit refuelling payload
- Co-passengers
 - 18 satellites in total
 - Commercial payloads from several nations

ISRO launch vehicles, private players and policy

India's launch vehicle family ranges from the early SLV and GSLV to the planned NGLV, which has a maximum payload capability of 30 tonnes. The SSLV serves small satellites and takes that load off the PSLV. Private firms such as Agnikul Cosmos are building their own rockets, which the Indian Space Policy 2023 allows.

- SLV: ISRO's first satellite launch vehicle, followed by ASLV
- GSLV: carries heavier satellites much deeper into space
- NGLV: maximum payload capability of 30 tonnes
- NGLV: about 3 times LVM3's payload capability at 1.5 times the cost
- SSLV: suited to launching multiple microsatellites; shifts burden from PSLV
- SSLV-D1 (2022) failed; SSLV-D2 (2023) succeeded
- Agnikul Cosmos (founded 2017): SOrTeD is a two-stage suborbital demonstrator
- Indian Space Policy 2023 lets private enterprises carry out end-to-end space activities
- RHUMI-1: India's first reusable hybrid rocket, developed by Space Zone India

Mind-map outline

Launch vehicles and policy

- ISRO vehicles
 - SLV: ISRO's first rocket
 - GSLV: heavier satellites, deeper space
 - NGLV: 30-tonne capacity
 - SSLV: small satellites, producer NSIL
- Private launchers
 - Agnikul Cosmos: SOrTeD
 - RHUMI-1: reusable hybrid
- Policy
 - Indian Space Policy 2023
 - Private end-to-end space activities
- Agencies
 - NSIL: commercial arm of ISRO
 - IN-SPACe: authorisation centre

Sports

National Sports Governance Act and India's Sports Framework

National Sports Board and Election Panel

The National Sports Board is the apex regulatory body for sports governance in India and can grant, renew, suspend or cancel recognition of national sports bodies. Its members are selected and appointed by a Search-cum-Selection Committee chaired by the Cabinet Secretary. A National Sports Election Panel, drawn from experienced former election officials, oversees elections in sports federations.

- Apex regulatory body for sports governance in India
- Powers: grant, renew, suspend or cancel recognition of National Sports Bodies
- Maintains a Central Register of Recognised Sports Bodies
- Board composition: Chairperson and 2 other members
- Search-cum-Selection Committee selects and appoints Board members
- Committee chaired by the Cabinet Secretary
- Committee includes Secretary (Ministry of Youth Affairs & Sports), 1 sports administration expert and 2 National Sports Award recipients
- Election Panel: central roster of experienced former election officials
- Election Panel must have at least 20 members at all times
- Board accounts are audited by the Comptroller and Auditor-General of India

Mnemonic - Board recognition powers: GRSC

G = Grant recognition to National Sports Bodies; R = Renew recognition; S = Suspend recognition; C = Cancel recognition

Mind-map outline

National Sports Board and Election Panel

- Board
 - Apex regulatory body
 - Chairperson and 2 other members
 - Grant, renew, suspend, cancel recognition
- Selection
 - Search-cum-Selection Committee
 - Chaired by Cabinet Secretary
 - 2 National Sports Award recipients
- Election Panel
 - Former election officials roster
 - At least 20 members at all times
 - Free, fair, transparent elections
- Accountability
 - Curbs politicisation and arbitrariness
 - Accounts audited by CAG

Rules 2026 and National Sports Bodies

The National Sports Governance (National Sports Bodies) Rules, 2026 require every national sports body to have a General Body and an Executive Committee; the General Body must include sportspersons, and the Executive Committee at least 4 women. The National Olympic Committee and National Paralympic Committee are the sole governing bodies for Olympic and Paralympic sports in India. Recognised sports bodies are deemed public authorities under the RTI Act 2005.

- Rules 2026 require every National Sports Body to have a General Body and an Executive Committee
- General Body must include at least 4 Sportspersons of Outstanding Merit (minimum 25 years of age)
- 50% of Sportspersons of Outstanding Merit in the General Body must be women
- Executive Committee must include at least 4 women members
- National Olympic Committee is the sole governing body for Olympic sports in India
- National Paralympic Committee is the sole governing body for Paralympic sports
- Other bodies include National Sports Federations and Regional Sports Federations
- Term of members: 3 years or up to 65 years of age, whichever is earlier
- A person convicted by a court and sentenced to imprisonment is disqualified
- Recognised sports bodies are deemed public authorities under the RTI Act 2005

Mind-map outline

Rules 2026 and National Sports Bodies

- General Body
 - At least 4 sportspersons of outstanding merit
 - Minimum age 25 years
 - 50% of them women
- Executive Committee
 - At least 4 women members
- Recognised bodies
 - NOC: sole Olympic governing body
 - NPC: sole Paralympic governing body
 - National and regional federations
- Members
 - Term: 3 years or up to 65 years
 - Disqualified if convicted and imprisoned
- Accountability
 - Deemed public authorities under RTI Act 2005

National Sports Tribunal

The National Sports Tribunal is set up for independent, speedy, effective and cost-efficient resolution of sports disputes. It is headed by a sitting or retired Supreme Court judge or a High Court Chief Justice, with two other members. Its jurisdiction covers election disputes, athlete selection issues and governance matters, but excludes major international events and doping-related disputes.

- Established for independent, speedy, effective and cost-efficient resolution of sports disputes
- Headed by a sitting or retired Supreme Court judge or Chief Justice of a High Court
- 2 other members who are experts in sports, public administration or law
- Jurisdiction: election disputes, athlete selection issues and governance matters
- Appellate authority: Supreme Court only
- Excluded: disputes during major international sporting events (Olympic, Paralympic, Commonwealth and Asian Games)
- Excluded: doping-related disputes, which fall under the National Anti-Doping Act 2022
- Doping-related disputes fall exclusively under the National Anti-Doping Act 2022

Mind-map outline

National Sports Tribunal

- Composition
 - Head: sitting or retired SC judge or HC CJ
 - 2 members: sports, administration or law experts
- Jurisdiction
 - Election disputes

- Athlete selection issues
- Governance matters
- Appeal
 - Supreme Court only
- Excluded
 - Major international sporting events
 - Doping-related disputes

Anti-Doping Framework

Anti-doping in India is handled by the National Anti-Doping Agency, set up under the Ministry of Youth Affairs & Sports, and by the National Anti-Doping Act, 2022. The Act is India's first standalone anti-doping law and is designed to comply with the WADA Code. The text also lists India's rankings in WADA and Athletics Integrity Unit doping data.

- National Anti-Doping Agency set up in 2005 under the Ministry of Youth Affairs & Sports
- National Anti-Doping Agency monitors doping control programmes
- National Anti-Doping Act, 2022 is India's first standalone anti-doping law
- The Act is designed for compliance with the WADA Code
- The Act gives powers for search, seizure and disciplinary action
- UNESCO International Convention (2005) urges nations to enact laws against drug use in sport; 191 countries including India
- Court of Arbitration for Sport was set up in 1984 by the International Olympic Committee, based in Switzerland
- WADA 2023 Report: India had the highest positivity rate for banned substances among major nations

Mind-map outline

Anti-Doping Framework

- Domestic law
 - National Anti-Doping Agency, 2005
 - National Anti-Doping Act, 2022
 - Powers: search, seizure, disciplinary action
- Global standards
 - WADA Code compliance
 - UNESCO Convention, 2005
 - Court of Arbitration for Sport, 1984
- India's rankings
 - Highest WADA positivity rate, 2023 report
 - 2nd among minors, after Russia
 - 2nd in track and field, after Kenya

Sports Initiatives and Performance

Government initiatives include Fit India, Khelo India, KIRTI and TOPS, which aim at fitness participation, talent identification and support for Olympic medal prospects. Mission Olympic Cell, within the Ministry of Youth Affairs & Sports, supports athletes under TOPS. Indian athletes' results at the Paris Olympics and Paralympics, and in chess, are noted in the text.

- Fit India Movement (2019) encourages mass participation in fitness activities
- Khelo India (2017) identifies and develops athletes at grassroots and elite levels
- KIRTI (2024) aims to identify talent among school children aged 9 to 18
- TOPS (2014) identifies and supports athletes with potential to win Olympic medals
- Mission Olympic Cell, within the Ministry of Youth Affairs & Sports, supports athletes' preparation under TOPS
- India won 6 medals at the Paris Olympics (1 silver and 5 bronze) and placed 71st in the medals tally
- Manu Bhaker won bronze in two 10 metre air pistol events and was the first Indian woman to win a shooting medal
- Aman Sehrawat is the youngest Indian to win an individual Olympic medal, a bronze at the 2024 Paris Olympics
- Praveen Kumar won gold in high jump at the 2024 Paris Paralympics

- D Gukesh became the world's youngest chess champion at 18, beating Ding Liren at the 2024 FIDE World Chess Championship in Singapore

Mnemonic - Scheme launch years: TOPS came in 2014, Khelo in 2017, Fit in 2019, KIRTI in 2024
 2014 = TOPS launched; 2017 = Khelo India launched; 2019 = Fit India Movement launched; 2024 = KIRTI Programme launched

Mind-map outline

Sports Initiatives and Performance

- Schemes
 - Fit India Movement, 2019
 - Khelo India, 2017
 - KIRTI, 2024 (ages 9 to 18)
 - TOPS, 2014
- Support
 - Mission Olympic Cell
 - Supports athletes under TOPS
- Paris 2024
 - 6 medals: 1 silver, 5 bronze
 - 71st in medals tally
 - Manu Bhaker: two bronze medals
- Other results
 - Praveen Kumar: Paralympic high jump gold
 - D Gukesh: youngest world chess champion

Miscellaneous

Miscellaneous

UN Security Council and Control Regimes

The UN Security Council is one of the six principal organs of the United Nations, established in 1945 under the UN Charter, and it has five permanent and ten non-permanent members. Its main purpose is maintaining international peace and security. Outside the Council, the Australia Group and the export control regimes NSG, MTCR and Wassenaar Arrangement work to limit the spread of dangerous weapons.

- UN Security Council is one of the six principal organs of the UN, established in 1945 under the UN Charter.
- Permanent members (P5): China, France, Russia, USA and UK.
- Ten non-permanent members; the General Assembly elects five each year for two-year terms.
- Non-permanent seats are distributed on a regional basis.
- UNSC presidency rotates every month among its 15 members.
- UNSC headquarters: New York City; it authorises peacekeeping missions and imposes sanctions.
- Coffee Club prime movers: Italy, Spain, Australia, Canada, South Korea, Argentina and Pakistan.
- Coffee Club opposes expansion of permanent seats; Italy and Spain are opposed to Germany's bid, and Pakistan to India's bid.
- Australia Group founded in 1985 after chemical weapons were used in the Iran-Iraq War; India joined in 2018.
- NPT adopted 1968, in force 1970, extended indefinitely 1995; North Korea withdrew in 2003.

Mnemonic - Export control regimes: Nice Men Wear: NMW for the three export control regimes
 N = Nuclear Suppliers Group (1975) regulates nuclear-related exports; M = Missile Technology Control Regime (1987) covers missile and drone technology; W = Wassenaar Arrangement (1996) controls conventional arms and dual-use goods

Mind-map outline

UN Security Council and control regimes

- UN Security Council
 - Established 1945 under UN Charter
 - Headquarters: New York City
 - Five permanent, ten non-permanent
- Non-proliferation and export controls

- Australia Group: founded 1985
- NSG (1975): nuclear-related exports
- MTCR (1987): missile and drone technology
- Wassenaar (1996): conventional arms, dual-use

Critical Technology and Mineral Security

Pax Silica is a US-led framework to build trusted technology supply chains, covering semiconductors, AI infrastructure, critical minerals and advanced manufacturing, and India is set to join it. The Minerals Security Partnership is a US-led alliance launched in 2022, and India is the only developing country to be part of it. India's National Critical Minerals Mission and KABIL aim to secure critical mineral assets at home and abroad.

- Pax Silica is a US-led multilateral framework; India is set to join it.
- Pax Silica scope: semiconductors and AI infrastructure, critical minerals and energy inputs, advanced manufacturing, compute and data logistics.
- Pax Silica members include the US, Japan, South Korea, Singapore, UK and Israel.
- Minerals Security Partnership: US-led alliance launched in 2022; India is the only developing country member.
- India and US launched iCET in 2022 for semiconductors, AI and wireless communication.
- National Critical Minerals Mission runs from FY 2024-25 to 2030-31; nodal ministry is Ministry of Mines.
- KABIL (Khanij Bidesh India Ltd) acquires exploration and exclusivity rights for five lithium brine blocks in Argentina.
- Samudravaan Project explores the Indian Ocean seabed for critical minerals.
- Lithium triangle: Argentina, Bolivia and Chile; top lithium reserves are Bolivia, Argentina and Chile.
- India's first lithium site is Salal-Haimana (Reasi, J&K); first auctioned site is Korba (Chhattisgarh).

Mnemonic - Lithium triangle: ABC of lithium: Argentina, Bolivia, Chile

A = Argentina is a lithium triangle country; B = Bolivia is a lithium triangle country and has the top lithium reserves; C = Chile is a lithium triangle country and a top lithium producer

Mind-map outline

Critical technology and minerals

- Pax Silica
 - US-led trusted supply chain framework
 - Scope: semiconductors, AI infrastructure, minerals
- Critical minerals
 - Minerals Security Partnership (2022)
 - National Critical Minerals Mission
 - KABIL: overseas acquisitions
- India's lithium sites
 - Salal-Haimana (Reasi, J&K): first site
 - Korba (Chhattisgarh): first auctioned site

Government Schemes and Governance Platforms

Swadesh Darshan, launched in 2015, develops theme-based tourism circuits, and its 2.0 version shifts to destination-centric and sustainable tourism. A CAG audit of PMKVY for 2015-2022 found weak planning, unspent funds, data lapses and poor placement outcomes. PMMVY is a conditional cash transfer for pregnant women and lactating mothers, while PRAGATI is a three-tier platform for monitoring projects and redressing grievances.

- Swadesh Darshan was launched in 2015 as a central sector scheme under the Ministry of Tourism.
- Swadesh Darshan 2.0 shifts from circuit-based to destination-centric infrastructure.
- PRASHAD focuses on infrastructure development at major pilgrimage and heritage sites.
- CAG audit of PMKVY (2015-2022): nearly 20% of state component funds remained unspent.
- PMKVY audit: about 95% of candidate records had invalid or missing information; placement rate only 41%.
- PMMVY launched in 2017 as a conditional cash transfer; incorporated into Mission Shakti in 2022.

- PMMVY targets pregnant women and lactating mothers aged 19 and above; Rs 5,000 for the first living child.
- PRAGATI, launched in 2015, is a three-tier monitoring and grievance redressal platform.
- PRAGATI integrates with CPGRAMS to address citizens' grievances.
- PM SVANidhi (2020) gives affordable working capital loans to street vendors and offers a PM SVANidhi credit card.

Mind-map outline

Government schemes and platforms

- Swadesh Darshan (2015)
 - Theme-based tourism circuits
 - 2.0: destination-centric approach
- PMKVY CAG audit
 - About 20% state funds unspent
 - Placement rate only 41%
- PMMVY (2017)
 - Conditional cash transfer for mothers
 - Part of Mission Shakti (2022)
- PRAGATI (2015)
 - Three-tier monitoring platform
 - Linked to CPGRAMS

Economy, Finance and Global Rankings

India overtook Japan to become the fourth-largest economy by nominal GDP, and its growth is described as the fastest among major economies. The OECD/G20 global minimum tax framework seeks a 15% minimum effective tax rate for large multinationals. Rankings such as the Henley Passport Index 2026 and NITI Aayog's Export Preparedness Index measure global mobility and state-level export readiness.

- India overtook Japan to become the world's fourth-largest economy in nominal GDP.
- Nominal GDP about \$4.18 trillion; per capita nominal GDP \$2,820, ranked 136th.
- Real GDP growth of 8.2% in Q2 of FY2025; described as the fastest-growing major economy.
- Food prices entered deflation at -0.2%, the first time since 2014.
- Global minimum tax: introduced by OECD in 2021; minimum 15% effective tax rate for large MNEs.
- Pillar 1 reallocates 25% of profits above a set margin to market jurisdictions.
- RBI State Finances 2025-26: states' consolidated fiscal deficit rose to 3.3% of GDP in 2024-25.
- Henley Passport Index 2026: India ranked 80th, up from 85th in 2025.
- Export Preparedness Index (4th edition): business ecosystem carries 40% weight.
- Payments Regulatory Board is chaired by the RBI Governor under the Payment and Settlement Systems Act 2007.

Mind-map outline

Economy, finance and rankings

- Global minimum tax (OECD, 2021)
 - Pillar 1: 25% of residual profits reallocated
 - Pillar 2: 15% minimum corporate tax
- India's economy
 - Fourth-largest by nominal GDP
 - Deflation: food prices at -0.2%
- RBI State Finances 2025-26
 - States' fiscal deficit 3.3% of GDP
 - Outstanding liabilities 28% of GDP
- Rankings
 - Henley Passport Index: India 80th
 - Export Preparedness Index: four pillars

Defence, Diplomacy and Resources

India and Germany marked 25 years of their strategic partnership during Chancellor Friedrich Merz's first official visit to India, signing agreements on defence, trade and mobility. India and Pakistan exchange lists of their nuclear installations every year under a 1988 agreement. India became the world's largest rice producer at about 150 million tonnes, while the Indus Waters Treaty faces renewed tensions.

- German Chancellor Friedrich Merz made his first official visit to India, marking 25 years of the strategic partnership.
- Germany announced a visa-free transit facility for Indian passport holders.
- Bilateral India-Germany trade crossed USD 50 billion in 2024.
- DRDO partners with Europe's OCCAR for the Eurodrone MALE UAV programme.
- Pinaka LRGR-120 has a range of approximately 120 km and was flight-tested at Chandipur, Odisha.
- Operation Pawan: Indian peacekeeping force in Sri Lanka, launched after the Indo-Sri Lanka Accord of 29 July 1987.
- India-Pakistan agreement on nuclear installations was signed on 31 December 1988 and entered into force on 27 January 1991.
- Indus Waters Treaty signed in 1960 with World Bank as broker; eastern rivers Ravi, Beas and Sutlej go fully to India.
- Sawalkot hydropower project on the Chenab (J&K) is a 1856 MW run-of-river project.
- India surpassed China to become the world's largest rice producer (about 150 million tonnes).

Mind-map outline

Defence, diplomacy and resources

- India-Germany partnership
 - 25 years of strategic partnership
 - Visa-free transit for Indian passports
 - Trade crossed USD 50 billion (2024)
- Defence
 - Pinaka LRGR-120: flight-tested in Odisha
 - Operation Pawan in Sri Lanka
 - Nuclear installations agreement (1988)
- Resources
 - Rice: about 150 million tonnes
 - Indus Waters Treaty (1960)
 - Sawalkot hydropower: 1856 MW